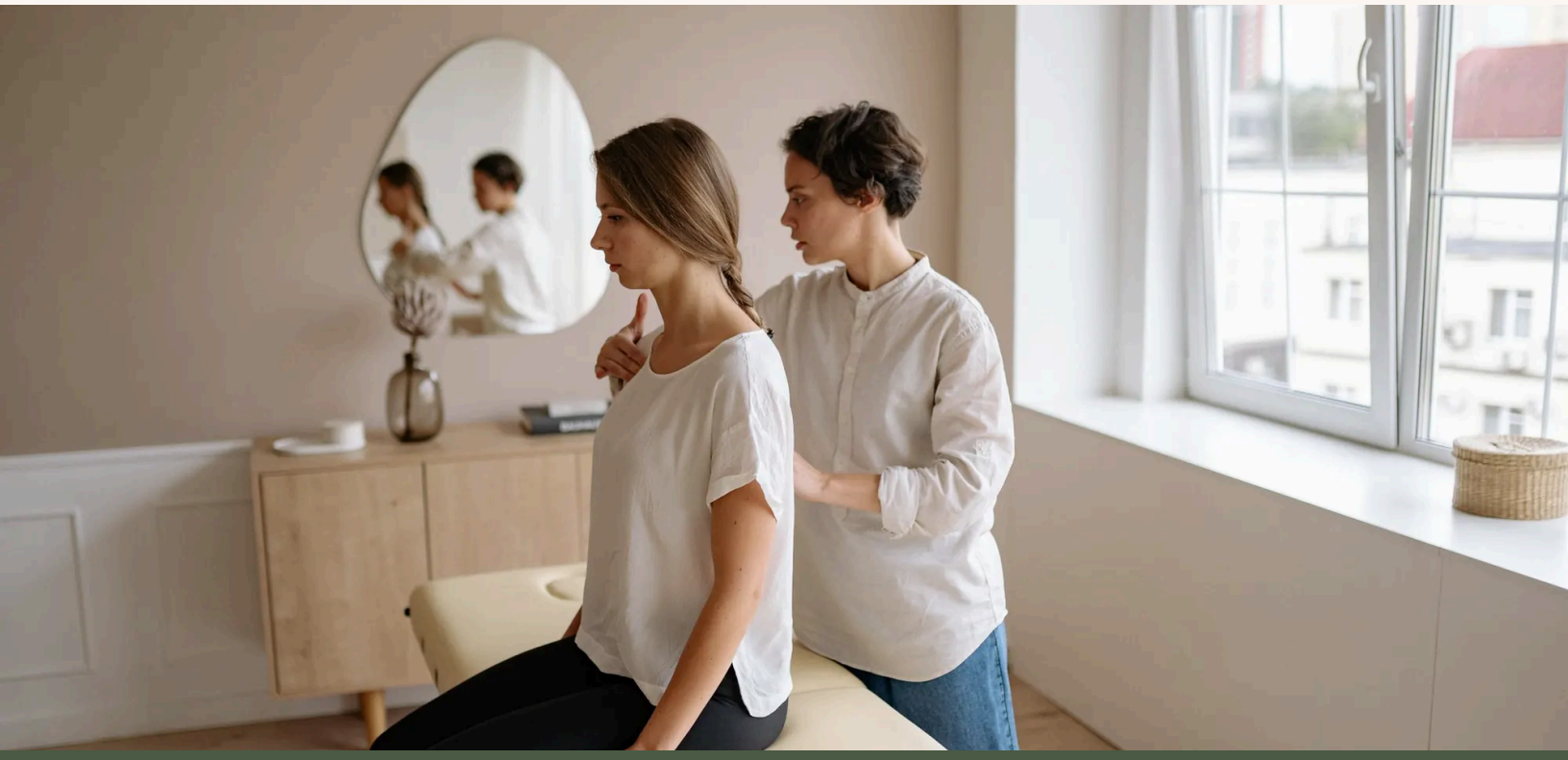
TAB | HUMAN PERFORMANCE CENTER
TRANSFORM. ADAPT. BALANCE.

Your First Massage

What to expect, how to prepare, and how to make the session your own.

Written by **TAB Human Performance Center** · October 2026



WELCOME

You don’t need to know anything to get started.

A first massage brings fair questions. What do I wear? Will it hurt? What if I don’t like something? This guide answers them plainly, so you can walk in knowing what to expect.

People come to a first massage for all kinds of reasons: a stiff neck that won’t settle, recovery from training or physical work, the changes of pregnancy, or simply wanting to feel more at home in their body. Some arrive knowing exactly what they want. Most don’t, and that’s fine. At TAB, we start where you are.

TAB Human Performance Center grew out of TAB Massage & Fitness, which has served clients in Livingston County, Michigan, since 2008. Massage & Bodywork is one of five services at TAB, and a natural place to begin.

This guide covers what massage can and can’t do, how to prepare, what happens at your first visit, and what to notice afterwards. It ends with a one-page checklist you can print or save.

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The short version

If you read nothing else, read this.

1. **You’re in control.** Pressure, focus, positioning, conversation: change any of it, at any time.
2. **Your comfort, your call.** You undress in private, only as far as you’re comfortable, and stay covered except where we’re working.
3. **Firmer isn’t better.** The right pressure is the one your body can accept without bracing.
4. **Health first.** We talk through your health privately at your visit. A few conditions call for a word with your healthcare provider first (page 4).
5. **Come 15 minutes early.** New clients complete a short intake, so none of your hands-on time is lost.

THE HONEST PICTURE

What massage can and can’t do

We’d rather you arrive with accurate expectations than big promises. Here’s what the research supports, in plain language.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SUGGESTS

Serious problems are rare

The U.S. National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health (NCCIH) describes the risk of harm from massage as low. The rare serious problems reported have mostly involved vigorous work or people at higher risk of injury.[1] That’s why we ask about your health first and adapt the pressure to you.

Evidence on pain is still developing

Research suggests massage may help neck and shoulder pain, though the benefit may be short-lived, and some fibromyalgia symptoms when it’s continued long enough. For low-back pain, headaches and other conditions, the evidence is weaker or mixed.[1]

You don’t need a problem to fix

Many people book massage to feel more comfortable in their body, to unwind, or to support recovery from training and physical work. Those are good reasons on their own.

WHAT MASSAGE ISN’T

A substitute for medical care

Massage doesn’t diagnose or treat medical conditions. If something feels wrong, see your healthcare provider rather than waiting for a massage to sort it out.[1]

A detox

You may hear that massage “flushes toxins.” There’s no good evidence for it; your liver and kidneys already do that job. More on page 8.

A test of toughness

More pressure doesn’t mean more benefit, and you never have to grit your teeth through a session. More on pages 6 and 7.

HOW WE THINK ABOUT MASSAGE

> *Restore capacity so the body has more room to move, recover and respond.*

Massage & Bodywork at TAB supports comfort, movement, recovery, body awareness and physical adaptability. When medical circumstances are involved, we work within professional scope and may ask for medical clearance, or coordinate with your healthcare team, before we begin.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

A little preparation goes a long way

Choosing a practitioner

In Michigan, massage therapists must be licensed by the state, and you can look up a license on the Department of Licensing and Regulatory Affairs (LARA) website.[2] It's also fair to ask about a practitioner's training and experience, and the kinds of work they do most.[1]

Pregnant?

Prenatal massage is adapted to each stage of pregnancy, with side-lying positions and supportive cushions so you can rest comfortably. Let us know how far along you are when you book.

What to tell us

What brings you in

A tight neck, training recovery, stress, or plain curiosity. Any reason is a good reason.

Your health

Conditions, recent injuries or surgery, medications, and pregnancy. We go over this privately at your visit.

What to avoid

Areas you'd rather we didn't work on, ticklish spots, or anything that felt wrong in a past massage.

Sensitivities

Allergies or sensitivities to oils, lotions or scents. Tell us about any rash, cut or skin infection, too.

Your preferences

Pressure, temperature, music, and whether you'd like to talk or stay quiet.

Your goals

What you'd like to feel or do afterwards. "Feel less stiff at my desk" is a perfectly good goal.

Please don't email us health details. We'll ask about them privately, in person, when you arrive.

Check with your healthcare provider first if you:

- have had surgery recently
- are being treated for cancer
- have, or have had, a blood clot, or take blood-thinning medication
- have osteoporosis, a recent fracture or a recent significant injury
- are managing a serious or changing health condition

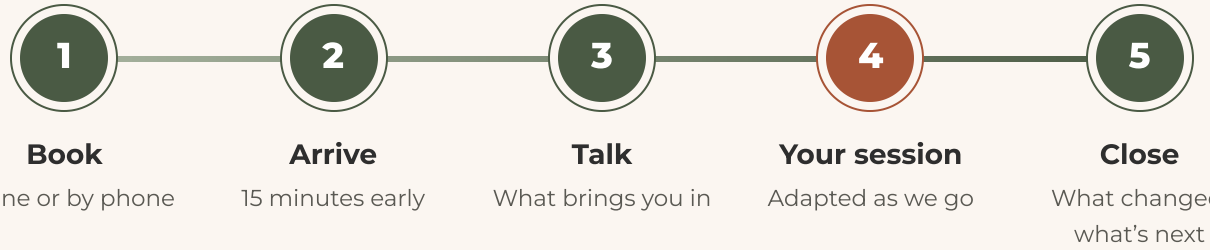
We may ask for medical clearance before your first session. It isn't a hurdle; it's how we make sure the work is right for you.

Feeling unwell on the day? If you have a fever or something contagious, call us. Your massage can wait until you're better.

YOUR FIRST VISIT

What happens, step by step

No surprises. Here's how a first appointment flows, from booking to heading home.



1

Book

Book online at tabhumanperformance.com or call (810) 844-1283. Not sure what to book? Use **Start Where You Are** on our website and we'll help you find the right starting point. If you have a preference for a particular technique, mention it when you book.

2

Arrive 15 minutes early

New clients complete a short intake form before the session, so none of your hands-on time is lost. Comfortable clothes are ideal. Our client policies, including 24 hours' notice to cancel or reschedule, are at tabhumanperformance.com/policies.

3

A short conversation

We go over what brings you in, relevant health information, and your preferences for pressure and focus. Ask anything; there are no silly questions. This is where we agree on a plan for the session together.

4

Your session

We step out while you undress to your comfort level and settle on the table under a sheet. The session is adapted to how you feel today, and you can adjust pressure, positioning or focus at any time.

5

Close and next steps

We close with what changed, what to notice over the next day or two, and what might support you next. Take your time sitting up before you get dressed.

ON THE TABLE

Comfort, privacy and pressure

The details people wonder about but don't always ask.

What to wear

Undress only as far as you're comfortable. Many people keep their underwear on, and that's completely fine. Some techniques work well over comfortable clothing; we'll tell you if that's the case.

Staying covered

A sheet covers you throughout. Only the area being worked on is uncovered, then covered again. Ask any time if you'd like it adjusted.

Positioning

You may start face down, with your face in a padded cradle, or face up. Side-lying with cushions is an option too, and the usual position in pregnancy. Too warm, too cool, need another pillow? Just say.

Talking

Chat or stay quiet: both are fine. Many people talk at first and drift into quiet, and some drift toward sleep. We'll still check in about pressure.

Finding the right pressure

Firmer isn't better. The right pressure is the one your body can accept without bracing. TAB's techniques span four levels; here's where each usually sits.



Very light

Craniosacral therapy
Manual lymphatic drainage



Gentle

Prenatal massage
Myomassology
Organ-specific fascial mobilization



Moderate

Neuromuscular therapy
Sports massage
Myofascial release
Active Release Techniques



Firm

Deep tissue massage
Trigger point therapy



You don't need to choose a technique. Most sessions blend several. Tell us how you feel and what you'd like to be different, and we'll choose and adjust as we go. Every technique is described on the Massage & Bodywork pages of our website.

SPEAK UP

You’re in control, the whole time

A good session is a conversation, even when it’s a quiet one. Your feedback is how we get it right.

How should it feel?

Comfortable

Feels good. You can breathe easily and stay relaxed. Keep going.

Intense, but OK

A strong sensation that eases as we work. You can still breathe slowly and let go. Tell us if it changes.

Too much

You hold your breath, tense up or pull away. That’s your signal to say so, and we’ll ease off straight away.

Things you can say

None of these will surprise us. We’d much rather hear them than have you put up with something.

- “Could you use a little less pressure there?”
- “That’s a good spot. Can you stay there a bit longer?”
- “I’m a little cold.”
- “I’d rather you didn’t work on my feet.” Or face, stomach, or anywhere else.
- “I’d like to keep quiet today.”
- “What are you noticing in that area?”

Pause, change or stop, any time.

You can pause, change or stop the session at any time, for any reason, and you never need to explain. The same goes for any area you’d rather we left alone.

MYTHS AND FACTS

Common myths, and what's true

A few ideas about massage that are worth retiring.

YOU MAY HAVE HEARD	WHAT'S TRUE
"It has to hurt to work."	**More pressure isn't more benefit.** Your body responds best to pressure it can accept without bracing. The rare serious problems linked to massage have mostly involved vigorous work.[1]
"Massage flushes toxins out of your muscles."	**There's no good evidence for this.** Your liver and kidneys clear waste, and one study found massage actually slowed the clearing of lactate from exercised muscle.[3] Water afterwards is still sensible: you've been lying still for a while.
"I need to know which technique to ask for."	**You don't.** Most sessions blend several techniques. Tell us how you feel and what you'd like to be different, and we'll choose and adjust as we go.
"I'll have to undress completely."	**Only as far as you're comfortable.** You stay covered except for the area being worked on, and some techniques are done fully clothed.
"Falling asleep, or a rumbling stomach, would be embarrassing."	**Both happen often, and nobody minds.** Neither do unshaved legs. There's nothing you need to do to get your body "ready." Come as you are.
"Massage is a luxury, or only for athletes."	**People book for all kinds of reasons.** Everyday tension, training recovery, pregnancy, changing health and simple comfort, at every stage of adult life and every fitness level.

AFTER YOUR SESSION

What to notice, and what helps

The hour on the table is only part of it. What you notice over the next day or two helps shape what comes next.

What's normal

- Feeling relaxed or sleepy, or a little light-headed when you first sit up. Sit up slowly and take a moment.
- Some tenderness for a day or two, especially after firmer work, much like after a new workout.
- Noticing areas you hadn't paid attention to before. That's body awareness, and it's useful.

What helps

- Drink water and eat as you normally would.
- Move gently: a walk or some easy stretching.
- Notice how you move, sit and feel, and tell us next time.
- Training hard soon? Tell us when you book, so we can time the work around it.

Call your healthcare provider if you notice

- pain that gets worse rather than easing after a couple of days
- new swelling, warmth or redness in an arm or leg
- numbness or tingling that doesn't settle
- anything that worries you

Then let us know too, so we can adapt your next session.

How often should I come?

It depends on what you're working on. We'll suggest a rhythm that fits your goals and your schedule, never more than you need.

The aim is more capacity on your own terms: more room to move, recover and respond in daily life, not dependence on the table.

BUILD OWNERSHIP, NOT DEPENDENCE

Massage connects with Functional Strength, Women's Wellness, Integrated Nutrition and Holistic Life Coaching when that genuinely supports your goals, and only then. Plenty of people simply book a massage, for as long as it helps.

Where massage fits: Transform. Adapt. Balance.

Transform	Adapt	Balance
Address tension, restrictions and recovery needs.	Improve the body's ability to respond and recover.	Recalibrate effort, restoration and physical demand.

CHECKLIST

Your first-massage checklist

Print it, save it, or skim it the night before.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

- [ ] Check page 4: do you need a word with your healthcare provider first?
- [ ] Think about what you'd like help with, and anything to avoid.
- [ ] Book online at tabhumanperformance.com or call (810) 844-1283.

ON THE DAY

- [ ] Eat lightly beforehand; lying face down on a full stomach isn't much fun.
- [ ] Wear comfortable clothes.
- [ ] Bring a list of any medications you take.
- [ ] Arrive 15 minutes early for your intake.

DURING

- [ ] Share your preferences: pressure, temperature, talking.
- [ ] Speak up any time. You're in control.

AFTER

- [ ] Sit up slowly.
- [ ] Drink water and move gently.
- [ ] Notice what changed, and tell us next time.

SOURCES AND NOTES

1 National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health (NCCIH). *Massage Therapy: What You Need To Know.* Last updated May 2019. nccih.nih.gov/health/massage-therapy-what-you-need-to-know

2 Michigan Department of Licensing and Regulatory Affairs (LARA), Board of Massage Therapy. License lookup at michigan.gov/lara.

3 Wiltshire EV, et al. Massage impairs postexercise muscle blood flow and "lactic acid" removal. *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise.* 2010;42(6):1062–71.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and it doesn't replace advice from your healthcare provider. TAB Human Performance Center provides massage and bodywork within professional scope and works alongside your healthcare team. Photographs are licensed stock images; the people shown are models, not TAB clients or staff.

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ONLINE
tabhumanperformance.com

CALL
(810) 844-1283

EMAIL
info@tabhumanperformance.com

VISIT
7487 Grand River Ave
Brighton, MI 48114

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